redeemed for. His great-great grandfather, Fateh Singh, fought in the 1840s for Maharajah Ranjit Singh's kingdom in the Anglo-Sikh Wars. Victory went to the British, and Fateh Singh ended up with half his land being confiscated by them. When he faced the chance to redeem himself, he had the impertinence to decline it. During the 1857 insurrection (during which the Sikhs of Punjab sided with the British), Sir John Lawrence offered to return the confiscated land to those who would join the British against the Great Revolt. Fateh Singh would have none of it. He staunchly refused to lend him his support. [3] The result was that he never saw the return of his lands.

By then Punjab had already been annexed following the fall of the Sikh Empire in 1849. Comprehensive systems of political governance were established in the province thereafter, to finance which the British instigated an efficient land revenue administration, so that from the 1860s onwards Punjab was seen as a 'model agricultural province' in which the loyalty and prosperity of its cultivators became a matter of high colonial priority. For a time, nationalist agitators had the wind taken out of their sails, and the British set out to reconcile political stability with agricultural development. This was easier said than done. [4] So, given its situation as a frontier region, through which invaders had flowed from the time of Alexander the Great, it had to be annexed. This was the political exigency of the day. After 1857, when the rest of India revolted, the rulers were left in little doubt that Punjab had a strategic location. The loyalty of Punjab in the so-called Indian Mutiny of 1857 only strengthened its status for the British. The province provided a stream of Muslim and Sikh soldiers. These helped the British to impose their authority on the rest of India, especially on the Gangetic Plains, where Punjabi soldiers saved British India in 1857. In 1901, five frontier states were annexed to become the North West Frontier Province, further emphasizing the distinctive importance of Punjab to the British. With the Indian Army drawing as much as three-fifths of its recruits from Punjab alone, 'the Punjabization of the Indian Army' was complete even though the Punjabis were only one-tenth of British India's total population. [5]